

Tamil, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they are written.

Companion practice lessons live alongside this book at
code/learning/human-languages/tamil/lessons/

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Preface

This is the Tamil volume of a wider project, and it is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Tamil letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read **வணக்கம்** *and* learn that it means “greetings” in the same few minutes. There is no alphabet drill to sit through first. (A reader who already reads Tamil simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Tamil rewards this depth more than most languages. It is the oldest-attested of the **Dravidian** tongues — a family entirely separate from the Indo-European one that gave us English, Latin, and Sanskrit — and it is famously protective of its own word-stock. Again and again you will find Tamil keeping a home-grown word (**வணக்கம்** *vaṇakkam*, “hello”; **நன்றி** *nanri*, “thanks”) where its sisters Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam reached for a Sanskrit one. So each lesson sets the word beside its cousins across the family — English always, and Sanskrit, Hindi, and the other Dravidian languages where they illuminate — every form supplied in full, so no prior knowledge of any of them is assumed.

Same three commitments as the other volumes: one word per lesson, gone deep; the widest *honest* web of connections; the cultural reason, not just the rule. Released under CC BY-SA 4.0.

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The Tamil script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words, each letter introduced as a word needs it. This page just gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a.”** க = ka, ம = ma, ர = ra.
2. **A vowel sign changes that built-in vowel.** ா = ā, ி = i, ீ = ī, ூ = u, ௃ = ū, ெ = e, ே = ē, ை = ai, ொ = o, ோ = ō.
(E.g. க ka + ி → கி ki.)
3. **A *pulli* (the dot, ◌̣) removes the built-in vowel.** க̣ = a bare *k*.
A vowel-less consonant then leans into the next.

Independent vowels (word-initial)

அ a · ஆ ā · இ i · ஈ ī · உ u · ஊ ū · எ e · ஏ ē · ஐ ai · ஒ o ·
ஔ ō · ஔ au.

What makes Tamil distinctive

- **Three *n*’s, three *l*’s, two *r*’s.** Place of articulation is written: dental ந / alveolar ண / retroflex ண்; ல ள ழ; ர ற. English fuses each set; Tamil keeps them apart, and they change meaning.
- **One letter, several sounds.** Tamil marks no voicing or aspiration: க can be *k*, *g*, or *h*; ச can be *s* or *ch* — **position** decides. The alphabet is small; the sound is read from context.

- **No Sanskrit-only letters in the core set.** Classical Tamil gets by with 18 consonants (a handful of *grantha* letters — ஜ, ஷ, ஸ, ஹ — are added only to spell loanwords).

Tamil in the Dravidian family

Tamil is the oldest-attested Dravidian language, and the one most protective of its native word-stock. Its sisters — Malayalam (closest), then Kannada and Telugu — share the grammar and many roots but borrowed far more freely from Sanskrit. The lessons trace, word by word, which Tamil words are home-grown and which its neighbours replaced.

Chapter 1

Greetings

The Tamil greetings and the words that oil a first conversation — and, taught through them, how to read the Tamil script and how Tamil sits inside the Dravidian family. Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs, so you learn to read the word and understand it at once. *Practice lessons: lessons/TA-C01-*.md.*

1.1 வணக்கம் (*vaṇakkam*) — “greetings,” a small act of respect

The letters in this word

Tamil reads **left to right**, and every consonant carries a built-in “a.” வ va, க ka, ம ma. ண is a **retroflex** *ṇ* (tongue curled back). The dot on top — a **puḷḷi** — *kills* the built-in vowel: க் is a bare *k*, so க்க is a held “kk.” Read வ·ண·க்·க·ம் → *vaṇakkam*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

வணக்கம் (*vaṇakkam*) comes from the verb வணங்கு (*vaṇaṅku*), “to bow, to pay homage.” Turned into a noun of the action, it means “a bowing, an act of reverence” — the idea of *namaste*, but from a **native Tamil** root, not a Sanskrit one. That is Tamil’s whole personality: an old language that keeps its home-grown words where its neighbours borrowed.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Watch “hello” split the family — four borrowed Sanskrit, Tamil alone kept its own:

Language	“Hello”	Source
Tamil	வணக்கம் <i>vaṇakkam</i>	native Dravidian
Kannada	<i>namaskāra</i>	Sanskrit
Telugu	<i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Malayalam	<i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Hindi	<i>namaste</i>	Sanskrit
English	<i>hello</i>	Germanic

Why it’s said this way

Said with the palms pressed together and a small bow — the gesture *is* the word. It serves as both **hello and goodbye**, any time, to almost anyone, respectful without being stiff.

1.2 நன்றி (*nanri*) — “thank you,” literally “goodness”

The letters in this word

New: ந *na* (**dental**, tongue on the teeth), ன் *n* (**alveolar**, on the ridge behind the teeth, with a pulli), and ர *ra*. The vowel sign ி makes “i” (றி = *ri*). Read ந·ன்·றி → *nanri*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நன்றி (*nanri*) grows from the root நல் (*nal*), “good” — so it literally means “**goodness**.” To thank, in Tamil, is to name the good someone did you.

Grammar Lens

Tamil hears three of every *n*, *l*, and *r*. You have now met ந (**dental** *n*), ன் (**alveolar** *n*), and ண் (**retroflex** *n*) — three letters for three tongue positions (on the teeth / on the ridge / curled back). Tamil does the

same for *l* (ல ள ழ) and *r* (ர ற ள). English fuses each set into one letter; Tamil keeps them apart, and the differences *change meaning*. Learn them word by word, not as a chart.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Thanks”	Note
Tamil	நன்றி <i>nanṛi</i>	native (<i>nal</i> , “good”)
Malayalam	<i>nandī</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian word
Kannada	<i>dhanyavāda</i>	Sanskrit
Telugu	<i>dhanyavādamulu</i>	Sanskrit
Hindi	<i>dhanyavād / shukriyā</i>	Sanskrit / Perso-Arabic

Malayalam, Tamil’s closest sister, kept the native word; Kannada and Telugu took the Sanskrit one — the family splits as it did over “hello.”

1.3 ஆம் (*ām*) — “yes”

The letters in this word

ஆ is the **independent vowel** “ā”: when a word *starts* with a vowel, Tamil uses a full vowel letter, not the little sign it hooks onto a consonant. ம் is a bare *m* (pulli). Read ஆம் → *ām*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ஆம் (*ām*) is the plain “yes.” Doubled for emphasis it becomes ஆமாம் (*āmām*), “yes, indeed.”

Grammar Lens

Tamil often says “yes” by **echoing the verb**: asked *vandāyā?* (“did you come?”), a natural yes is *vandēn* (“I came”). Bank *ām* as the simple word, but expect a “yes” to come back as a whole verb.

1.4 இல்லை (*illai*) — “no,” and how Tamil says a thing is *not*

The letters in this word

இ is the independent vowel “i” (word-initial, like ஆ). ல் is a bare *l* (pulli); லை is *lai* (the consonant ல with the vowel sign ை for “ai”). Read இ·ல்·லை → *illai*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

இல்லை (*illai*) is built on இல் (*il*), “not-being, absence” — so it is not really the adjective “no” but the statement “[it] is not, [there] is not.” Its positive twin is உண்டு (*undu*), “there is.”

Grammar Lens

Tamil negates by *being*, not with a “not”-word. Where English inserts *not/no*, Tamil swaps in the negative verb of existence: *puttakam undu* (“there is a book”) → *puttakam illai* (“there is not a book”). So *illai* is both the everyday “no” and the word that makes a whole sentence negative — a deeply Dravidian habit, unlike English or Hindi.

1.5 சரி (*sari*) — “okay,” the word that oils every conversation

The letters in this word

ச is one letter doing the work of English *s*, *ch*, and *j* — Tamil gives voicing no separate letters, so **position** decides the sound (just as க can be *k*, *g*, or *h*). ரி is *ri*. Read ச·ரி → *sari*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

சரி (*sari*) is native Tamil for “correct, even, level,” and so “okay, agreed.” It is the verbal nod of the language: propose a plan, hear a warm *sari*; doubled, *sari sari* = “alright, alright.”

Grammar Lens

One letter, several sounds. For its stop-consonants Tamil writes *one* letter per mouth-position and lets rules of position fill in the voicing (*k/g*, *s/ch*). The payoff is a strikingly *small* alphabet; the price is that the exact sound isn't always predictable from the letter alone — you pick it up by ear, word by word.

1.6 Recap, and how Tamil says goodbye

Read		Meaning
வணக்கம்	<i>vaṇakkam</i>	hello / greetings
நன்றி	<i>nanri</i>	thank you
ஆம்	<i>ām</i>	yes
இல்லை	<i>illai</i>	no / there isn't
சரி	<i>sari</i>	okay / correct

Why it's said this way

Why Tamil won't just say “I'm leaving.” The everyday goodbye is போய் வருகிறேன் (*pōy varugirēn*) — literally “I'll *go and come* [back],” and the reply is போய் வா (*pōy vā*), “go, and come back.” A bare “I go” sounds like a final parting, so you always promise a return. A whole worldview folded into a farewell. (Or simply say *vaṇakkam* again — it parts as well as it meets.)

Next chapter: introducing yourself — *en peyar...* (“my name...”) — and Tamil's *nī* / *nīṅgaḷ* (familiar / respectful “you”).

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

என் பெயர் அருண். (*en peyar Arun* — “My name is Arun.”)
உங்கள் பெயர் என்ன? (*uṅgaḷ peyar enna* — “What is your name?”)

Built the same way as the greetings — each piece taken apart, its letters and its root, then assembled. And here the roots run *native*: this is where Tamil is most itself. *Practice lessons: lessons/TA-C02-*.md.*

2.1 பெயர் (*peyar*) — “name,” and where the family is *not* Indo-European

The letters in this word

ப (*pa*) + ெ (the *e*-sign, written before, read after) → பெ (*pe*); ய (*ya*); ர் (bare *r*, with the pulli). Read பெ·ய·ர் → *peyar*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

பெயர் (*peyar*, “name”) is **native Dravidian**, from Proto-Dravidian *peyar / *pēr — and it is *not* related to the Sanskrit *nāma* (Hindi *nām*, English *name*). Here the two great families part: where Indo-European shares one word for “name” from Ireland to North India, the Dravidian south kept its own. That is the whole reason to learn Tamil deeply — it preserves a word-stock older than the Sanskrit layer.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Name”	Source
Tamil	பெயர் <i>peyar</i>	native Dravidian (*peyar)
Malayalam	<i>pēr</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian root
Telugu	<i>pēru</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian root
Kannada	<i>hesaru</i>	Dravidian (*pesar, with p→h)
Hindi	<i>nām</i>	Sanskrit <i>nāman</i> (Indo-European)
English	<i>name</i>	Indo-European

Four Dravidian tongues share *peyar/pēru*; only the Indo-European languages have *name/nām*.

2.2 என் (*en*) — “my”

The letters in this word

எ (independent vowel *e*, word-initial) + ன் (bare alveolar *n*, pulli) → *en*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

என் (*en*, “my”) is the possessive of நான் (*nān*, “I”) — native Dravidian, from the pronoun stem *yān / *nān. It has *no* Indo-European cousin: the Tamil “I/my” is built on a different root from the English *I* / *my* (which go back to *eǵ and *me-). Two families, two entirely separate words for the self.

2.3 என் பெயர் ... (*en peyar ...*) — “my name is...,” with no “is”

என் (my) + பெயர் (name) + name = **en peyar ...** *En peyar Arun.* = “My name is Arun.”

Grammar Lens

Tamil has no word for “is” here. Notice what’s missing: there is *no* verb. Tamil simply places “my name” beside “Arun” — *en peyar Arun* — and the “is” is understood. This is the **zero copula**: for equational

2.4. நீ / நீங்கள் (NĪ / NĪṅḡal) — “YOU,” FAMILIAR AND RESPECTFUL¹¹

sentences (X is Y), Dravidian needs no “to be” at all, where English needs *is*, Hindi needs *hai*, and Arabic (you’ll see) also drops it. Tamil says only “my name Arun.”

2.4 நீ / நீங்கள் (*nī* / *nīṅḡal*) — “you,” familiar and respectful

The letters in this word

நீ: ந (dental *na*) + ீ (the long-ī sign) → *nī*. நீங்கள் adds ங்கள் (*ṅgal*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நீ (*nī*, familiar “you”) ← Proto-Dravidian **nīn* — native, unrelated to the European “you” words (which come from **tū*). நீங்கள் (*nīṅḡal*) is *nī* + the plural ending *-kal*.

Grammar Lens

Respect by the plural — again. Tamil grades “you” in two: *nī* (familiar — friends, children) and *nīṅḡal* (respectful — and literally the *plural*, “you-all”). This is the *same* politeness-by-plural you would find in French *vous* — address one respected person as “you all.” For a first meeting, always *nīṅḡal*.

2.5 என்ன (*eṇṇa*) — “what”

The letters in this word

எ (*e*) + ண் (bare *n*) + ன (*na*) → *eṇṇa* — a doubled, held *nn*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

என்ன (*eṇṇa*, “what”) is native Dravidian, on the interrogative stem **yā-* / **e-* that heads Tamil’s whole question family: *eṇṇa* (what), *yār* (who), *eppo* (when), *enge* (where), *ēn* (why). Like Hindi’s *k-* words and English’s *wh-* words — but from a *different* root, the Dravidian one.

2.6 உங்கள் பெயர் என்ன? (*uṅgaḷ peyar enṇa*) — “what’s your name?”

உங்கள் (*uṅgaḷ*, “your”) is the possessive of *nīṅgaḷ* (“you,” respectful). So உங்கள் பெயர் என்ன? is literally “**your name what?**” — and again no “*is*”: the zero copula holds for questions too. Just three words, no verb.

Grammar Lens

Answer with the sentence you built: *En peyar Arun*. The familiar version swaps *uṅgaḷ* for *un* (“your,” from *nī*): *un peyar enṇa*?

2.7 மகிழ்ச்சி (*magilcci*) — “joy,” and “pleased to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The warm close is உங்களை சந்தித்ததில் மகிழ்ச்சி (*uṅgaḷai sandit-tatil magilcci*) — “**in having met you, joy.**” The key word மகிழ்ச்சி (*magilcci*, “joy, gladness”) is native Dravidian, from *magil* (“to rejoice”). It carries the ழ (*ḷ*) — a sound almost unique to Tamil, a retroflex glide with no English equivalent. (In casual speech Tamils often just smile, or say the English “nice to meet you.”)

2.8 The whole exchange

Tamil		English
என் பெயர் மீரா.	<i>en peyar Mira</i>	My name is Mira.
உங்கள் பெயர் என்ன?	<i>uṅgaḷ peyar enṇa</i>	What’s your name?
என் பெயர் அருண்.	<i>en peyar Arun</i>	My name is Arun.
மகிழ்ச்சி.	<i>magilcci</i>	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom native and traced: *peyar* (Dravidian **peyar*, *not name*), *en* (from *nān*, “I”), *enṇa* (Dravidian question-stem). And the Tamil habit to keep: the **zero copula** — an equational sentence needs no “is” at all. Next chapter: *eppaḍi irukkīṅgaḷ?* (“how are you?”) and answering with *nallā* — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has — and, for the first time, Tamil reaches for a verb “to be”:

நீங்கள் எப்படி இருக்கிறீர்கள்? (*nīṅgaḷ eppaṭi irukkiṟīrgaḷ* — “How
are you?”)
நான் நலமாக இருக்கிறேன். (*nāṇ nalamāga irukkiṟēṇ* — “I’m
well.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/TA-C03-.md.*

3.1 எப்படி (*eppaṭi*) — “how,” another of the e-questions

The letters in this word

எ (*e*) + ப் (*ppa*) + டி (*ṭi*) → எப்படி (*eppaṭi*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

எப்படி (*eppaṭi*, “how”) is native Dravidian — the interrogative base எ (*e-*) + *paṭi* (“manner”), “in what manner.” Tamil’s questions nearly all begin with this **e-**: *eṇṇa* (what), *eppaṭi* (how), *eppōdu* (when), *eṇḡē* (where), *ēṇ* (why). Where Hindi gathers questions under *k-* and English under *wh-*, Tamil gathers its own under **e-** — a separate, older family.

3.2 நீங்கள் எப்படி இருக்கிறீர்கள்? — “how are you?”

The new word is இருக்கிறீர்கள் (*irukkīrīrgal*): the verb stem இரு (*iru*, “to be, exist, stay”) + present + ீர்கள் (*-īrgal*, “you,” respectful). The verb comes last, as always.

Grammar Lens

Now the copula returns. Chapter 2 showed Tamil drops “is” for equations (*eṇ peyar Arun*, “my name Arun”). But “how are you?” is about a *state* — how you *exist* — and for that Tamil does use a verb, இரு (*iru*). So: no verb for “my name is Arun,” a real verb for “how are you.” The ending *-īrgal* already means “you (respectful),” so *nīngal* can be dropped.

3.3 நான் (*nāṇ*) — “I,” the Dravidian first person

The letters in this word

ந (dental *na*) + ா (long *ā*) + ன் (*ṇ*) → நான் (*nāṇ*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நான் (*nāṇ*, “I”) ← Proto-Dravidian **yāṇ* / **nāṇ* — native, and (unlike Hindi’s *main*, cousin of English *me*) **not** related to the European “I/me” family. Its possessive is the என் (*eṇ*, “my”) you already met: *nāṇ* “I,” *eṇ* “my.” Tamil’s “I” is a clear marker that Dravidian grew up apart from the Indo-European world around it.

3.4 நலம் (*nalam*) — “well,” and how to answer

The letters in this word

ந (*na*) + ல (*la*) + ம் (*m*) → நலம்.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நலம் (*nalam*, “wellness, welfare”) is native Dravidian, from நல் (*nal-*, “good”) — the root behind நல்ல (*nalla*, “good”) and நன்றி (*nanṛi*, “thanks,” literally “goodness,” from Chapter 1). So “thank you” and “I’m well” share a root: both are *nal-*, “good.”

Assemble: நான் நலமாக இருக்கிறேன் (*nāṇ nalamāga irukkīrēṇ*) — “I am well” (*nalam* + *-āga* “in a ... way” + *iru* + “I”). Casually: *nallā irukkēṇ*.

3.5 பரவாயில்லை (*paravāyillai*) — “no problem”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

பரவாயில்லை literally “**there is no harm**” — *paravāy* (“harm”) + இல்லை (*illai*, “is-not”). It serves as “it’s okay / no worries / you’re welcome.” The atom இல்லை (*illai*), from Chapter 1, is the Tamil “is-not,” the mirror of *iru* (“is”). It is shared, almost unchanged, across Tamil, Kannada, and Malayalam (*illa*) — a deep Dravidian bond; only Telugu breaks away to *lēdu*.

Grammar Lens

Illai negates existence and equations alike: *nāṇ illai* (“it’s not me”), *paṇam illai* (“there’s no money”), and, alone, plain “no.” Hold *iru* / *illai* together — “is” and “is-not.”

3.6 The whole exchange

Tamil	English
நீங்கள் எப்படி இருக்கிறீர்கள்?	How are you?
நான் நலமாக இருக்கிறேன், நன்றி.	I’m well, thank you.
பரவாயில்லை.	No problem / you’re welcome.

Every atom traced: *eppaṭi* (the native *e-* questions), *nāṇ* (Proto-Dravidian, unrelated to *me*), *nalam* (*nal-* “good,” the root of *nanṛi*), and the *iru* / *illai* pair — “is” and “is-not.” Next chapter: the farewells — and Tamil never says a plain “goodbye.”

Chapter 4

Farewells

Tamil does not say a plain “goodbye.” It says something warmer, and stranger to English ears — “I’ll go and *come back*”:

போய் வருகிறேன். (*pōy varugirēṇ* — “I’ll go and come back.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/TA-C04-.md.*

4.1 போ (pō) — “go,” and வா (vā) (come)

The letters in this word

ப (pa) + ோ (long ō) → போ (pō). Its partner வா (vā, “come”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

போ (pō, “go”) and வா (vā, “come”) are native Dravidian verbs of the deepest layer — single syllables, whole words on their own: *pō!* (“go!”), *vā!* (“come!”). You need both, because Tamil’s goodbye is “I go, and I *come back*.”

4.2 போய் வருகிறேன் (*pōy varugirēṇ*) — “I’ll go and come back”

போய் (*pōy*, “having gone”) + வருகிறேன் (*varugirēṇ*, “I come”) — literally “**having gone, I come**,” i.e. “I’ll go and come back.” A Tamil speaker never signs off with a bare “I’m leaving” — it sounds final, ill-omened. The reply is warm: போய் வா (*pōy vā*, “go and come [back]”).

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“go and come back” (goodbye)
Tamil	<i>pōy varugirēṇ</i>
Kannada	<i>hōgi baruttēne</i>
Telugu	<i>velli vastānu</i>
Malayalam	<i>pōyi varām</i>
Bengali (Indo-Aryan)	<i>āshi</i> (“I come”)
Hindi (Indo-Aryan)	<i>phir milenge</i> (“we’ll meet again”)

The whole subcontinent, Dravidian and Indo-Aryan alike, prefers a promise of return to a blunt farewell.

Grammar Lens

The “having ...d” participle. *Pōy* chains actions: “having gone, (then) I come.” Tamil strings verbs like beads — all but the last in a participle form, the last fully conjugated.

4.3 நாளை பார்க்கலாம் (*nālai pārkkalām*) — “see you tomorrow”

The letters in this word

நாளை (*nālai*): நா (*nā*) + னை (*lai*, retroflex ள *ḷ*). பார்க்கலாம் (*pārkkalām*) = பார் (*pār* “see”) + *-kkalām* (“let’s / we may”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நாளை (*nālai*, “tomorrow”) is native, from நாள் (*nāl*, “day”). பார் (*pār*, “to see”); so the phrase is “tomorrow, let’s see [each other].” Note the retroflex ள (*ḷ*), tongue-tip curled up and back — a sound English lacks.

4.4. மீண்டும் சந்திப்போம் (MĪṆṬUM SANDIPPŌM) — “WE’LL MEET AGAIN”¹⁹

4.4 மீண்டும் சந்திப்போம் (*mīṇṭum sandippōm*) — “we’ll meet again”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

மீண்டும் சந்திப்போம் = மீண்டும் (*mīṇṭum*, “again”) + சந்திப்போம் (*sandippōm*, “we will meet”). Two vocabularies in two words: *mīṇṭum* is **native Dravidian** (from *mīl*, “to return”); சந்தி (*sandi*, “to meet”) is a **Sanskrit** loan — from *sandhi* (“a joining”), the very term Sanskrit grammar uses for how sounds join at a boundary. A Dravidian core beside a Sanskrit borrowing — the recurring thread of this track.

4.5 The farewells

Tamil	English
போய் வருகிறேன்.	I’ll go and come back. (goodbye)
போய் வா.	Go and come back. (the reply)
நாளை பார்க்கலாம்.	See you tomorrow.
மீண்டும் சந்திப்போம்.	We’ll meet again.

Roots banked: *pō/vā* (the oldest verbs), *nāl* (“day” inside “tomorrow”), and *mīṇṭum* (native) beside *sandi* (Sanskrit). Next chapter: the first real verbs — *nāṇ tamil pēsugirēṇ* — and Tamil’s sentences begin to move.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now, “to be” and “to be-not.” Now verbs that *act* — and Tamil’s sentences begin to move:

நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன். (*nāṇ tamīḻ pēsugirēṇ* — “I speak Tamil.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/TA-C05-.md.*

5.1 பேசு (*pēsu*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The letters in this word

ப (*pa*) + ே (long *ē*) + சு (*su*) → பேசு (*pēsu*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

பேசு (*pēsu*, “to speak”) is native Dravidian; the bare stem is also the command “speak!” To say “I speak,” Tamil stacks two endings on the stem — **tense** then **person**:

pēsu- (speak) + *-gir-* (present) + *-ēṇ* (“I”) → பேசுகிறேன்
(*pēsugirēṇ*), “I speak.”

The *-ēṇ* ending is “I,” so the word *nāṇ* is rarely needed. Change the ending, change the person: *pēsugirāṇ* (he), *pēsugirāl* (she), *pēsugirārgal* (they / you-respectful).

Grammar Lens

Stem + tense + person. Every Tamil verb is built this way — a stem, a tense-marker, a person-ending, glued in that order. Learn the

pattern once and every verb follows it.

5.2 நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன் — “I speak Tamil”

நான் (I) + தமிழ் (*tamiḷ*, “Tamil,” the object) + பேசுகிறேன் (speak) — “I Tamil speak,” verb last. The name தமிழ் (*tamiḷ*) ends in the famous ழ (*ḷ*), a curled retroflex between “r,” “l,” and “zh” found in almost no other language — Tamil is sometimes called “the *ḷ* language.” It names one of the oldest living literary tongues on earth, its poetry two thousand years old and still read.

Grammar Lens

No gender on “I speak.” *Pēsugirēṇ* is the same whether a man or a woman says it — Tamil marks **no gender in the first or second person** (only the third: *-āṇ* he / *-āḷ* she). This is unlike Hindi, where even “I speak” changes for the speaker’s gender (*boltā/boltī*). Tamil saves gender for “he/she/it.”

5.3 வாழ் (*vāḷ*) — “to live, to flourish”

The letters in this word

வா (*vā*) + ழ (*ḷ*, the retroflex from *tamiḷ*) → வாழ் (*vāḷ*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

வாழ் (*vāḷ*, “to live, flourish, thrive”) is native, warmer than a plain “reside.” From it: வாழ்க்கை (*vāḷkkai*, “life”) and the blessing வாழ்க (*vāḷga*, “may you live / long live”), as in *vāḷga tamiḷ*. “I live” = நான் வாழ்கிறேன் (*nāṇ vāḷgirēṇ*) — the same stem + present + “I” as *pēsugirēṇ*.

5.4 வேலை செய் (*vēlai sey*) — “to work”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

செய் (*sey*, “to do, make”) is a core native verb, and Tamil — like Hindi with *karnā* — builds compounds by putting a noun in front of it: வேலை செய் (*vēlai sey*, “work-do” = “to work”), *samaiyal sey* (“to cook”), *udavi sey* (“to help”). So “I work” is நான் வேலை செய்கிறேன் (*nāṇ vēlai seygiṟēṇ*).

Grammar Lens

Noun + செய் = a new verb — the exact twin of Hindi’s “noun + *karnā*” (*kām karnā*). Two unrelated families, Dravidian and Indo-Aryan, hit on the same trick: an all-purpose “do” verb with nouns bolted on. Millennia side by side, Tamil and Hindi quietly traded habits like this.

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Tamil	English
நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன்.	I speak Tamil.
நான் சென்னையில் வாழ்கிறேன்.	I live in Chennai.
நான் வேலை செய்கிறேன்.	I work.

Three verbs, one engine: a stem, a tense-marker, a person-ending, the verb always last — and no gender in the first person. Roots banked: *pēsu* (speak), *vāl* (live → *vāḷkkai* “life,” *vāḷga* “long live”), *sey* (do → *vēlai sey* “to work,” the twin of Hindi’s *karnā*), and *tamiḷ* itself, with its signature retroflex *ḷ*. From here, Tamil’s sentences only grow.